PHOTOGRAPHS BY RICK RICH

Simple pen

Rick Rich shows you how to create a simple, low-cost pen

HANDY HINTS

1. When drilling, retract the bit frequently to remove wood from the bit grooves. This allows it to continue cutting cleanly. A little wax on the bit will also help
2. A revolving centre with a 60° point in the drilled hole keeps the blank centred
3. No matter what type of insert you use, you need to measure the tube diameter as well as the section that will fit into your turned body. Inserts vary in style, so take time to get all the information before starting

RICK RICH

Rick Rich is a part-time woodturner from Washington State. His completed woodturning projects are usually given as gifts to friends and family. He is a member of the American Association of Woodturners (AAW), the Cascade Woodturners in Portland, Oregon and is a founding member of the Southwest Washington Woodturners in Vancouver, Washington.

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The biggest problem with trying to turn a Bic®-style insert pen is the drill bit. It takes a 3mm drill bit for the ink tube and a 4mm bit for the tip. The only 3mm bits I had were of a normal length, which were too short. Compensating for the too short bits involves cutting the ink tube, which can lead to messy results.

One day I saw a long 3mm bit in a set of electrician length drill bits at the right price. I thought it would be perfect to use for an insert pen. However, the bit had a mind of its own and wandered to and fro while drilling. I never knew when it would pop out the side. My drilling success was at about 50% or less, which was indeed frustrating.

Months later, I happened to be in a hardware shop and saw a 3mm drill bit that was slightly longer than average and was 'extra stout'. This was what I needed and was about the price of a slimline pen kit. After making a few pens for gifts, I was bragging to my woodturning neighbour, Dan, about how easy they were to make. Curiosity getting the best of him, he had to come try his hand. He could have tried it at his own shop, but he didn't have the secret weapon; a long and strong 3mm drill bit.

EQUIPMENT USED

13mm skew chisel
10mm spindle gouge with fingernail grind
20mm spindle roughing gouge
150mm long 'aircraft size' 3mm drill bit
Normal length 3.5mm and 4mm drill bits
Chuck with spigot jaws
Revolving tailstock centre with 60° point
PPE, including full facemask

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